

Chapter 3

Can't Buy Me Love

As a birthday gift for my mother-in-law one year, Eric and I (Jill) attempted to digitize old family VHS videos. We didn't get too far with this. It's a long process. But we did get to enjoy one particular scene from Christmas morning 1992 when the whole family got a computer. It was Eric's older brothers who got to unwrap the computer and desktop screen. It was a big gift, and they were over the moon excited. Then the camera cuts to four-year-old Eric unwrapping his gift, only to reveal a power strip. Trying not to show disappointment, he shouted "A PLUG!" Seeing what his brothers got, I can only imagine what his little brain was thinking when he received an extension cord. But he played it cool and tried to make it seem like it was what he always wanted. We laughed so hard watching it all unfold.

Rest assured Eric got to play his fair share of Math Blaster on the new computer. But it got me thinking that his Christmas morning experience is often how life can feel. When everyone around us seems to be acquiring big, new, cool gadgets and all we can afford is a power strip, it's hard to hide our disappointment. People say money doesn't buy love, happiness, or joy, but most of us would rather be sad in a Range Rover than a rusting car. We need money to support the things we love, even if luxury vehicles will never be something we buy.

So, what happens when you have "computer" values but only "plug" money? When you're finding it hard to afford what you love, there are many solutions, the most obvious being to make more money. While we do